

Slug Housing App

Simplifying Campus Housing Discovery

When UCSC students lose the campus housing lottery, they're left searching fragmented rental sites with hidden costs, unverified listings, and no way to gauge roommate fit, often on a tight, urgent timeline. Slug Housing is an end-to-end product design and prototyping project that reimagines that search from the ground up.

UX Research

Information Architecture

Figma Prototyping

Usability Testing

Sahana Vijay

UX Research · Information Architecture · Figma Prototyping

The Problem, the Users, and Our Bet



What is Slug Housing?

A student-focused housing discovery platform that demystifies off-campus search near UC Santa Cruz: preference-based matching, tailored listing feeds, transparent cost breakdowns, and direct landlord messaging in place of scattered Facebook groups and email chains.



Who, and why now?

Target users are UCSC students shut out of on-campus housing by lottery cutoffs, searching under real time pressure. General real estate platforms weren't built for them: information is fragmented, utility costs are hidden until move-in, leases rarely match a school-year timeline, and there's zero context on who you'd actually be living with.

Our bet

If we replace open-ended browsing with a short preference survey up front, students reach listings that already fit their budget, distance, and roommate needs, cutting the anxious, unfocused scroll that dominates the current search experience. Every design decision on the following slides traces back to testing that bet.

What Students Needed vs. What We Built

1

Affordability & clarity

Students on tight financial-aid budgets can't afford surprises.

→ **Upfront rent, deposit, and utility breakdowns on every listing.**

2

Verified listings

Urgent timelines leave students exposed to rental scams.

→ **Clear photos and landlord verification before a listing goes live.**

3

Direct contact

Email chains get lost; inquiries go unanswered for days.

→ **Built-in messaging replaces external, easily-dropped threads.**

4

Fast filtering

Students need to rule listings in or out in seconds, not minutes.

→ **One-tap filters for price, distance from UCSC, and open roommate slots.**

Getting Inside the Student's Search

SAY

- "I need housing close to campus."
- "I'm worried about scams."
- "I don't know which listing is reliable."
- "I want something affordable."

THINK

- "Is this landlord trustworthy?"
- "What if I don't get a response?"
- "Is the price negotiable?"
- "Can I really afford this?"

DO

- Scrolls through listings
- Compares prices across tabs
- Opens detail pages
- Sends messages, checks for replies

FEEL

- Anxious about housing
- Overwhelmed by scattered options
- Frustrated by unclear listings
- Relieved once something's confirmed

Key takeaway: the emotional arc is anxiety → relief, not indifference → delight. That reframed the design goal from "make browsing fun" to "get students to a confident decision fast", which is what drove the preference-survey-first flow on the next slides.

Designing Around John and Sarah

PRIMARY PERSONA

John Cruz

1st-Year UCSC Student

GOAL

Secure affordable housing near UCSC transit lines quickly, before the term starts.

PAIN POINTS

First time living independently, tight financial-aid budget, worried about homelessness after missing the housing lottery.

SECONDARY PERSONA

Sarah Lin

Junior Transfer Student

GOAL

Find compatible housemates and a flexible 9-month sublease near downtown Santa Cruz.

PAIN POINTS

Incompatible roommate habits in the past; struggles to evaluate utility splits and lease terms remotely.

A third lens, **Marcus Vance, a Santa Cruz property manager**, informed the design too: landlords are bombarded with spam inquiries and want fast, direct communication with verified UCSC applicants. That's the other half of why the contact flow (see last block on slide 8) skips email entirely.

From Lottery Rejection to Signed Lease

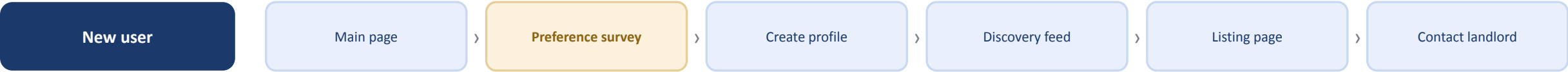
Stage	User Actions	Emotion	Expectations & Risks
1. Discovery	Loses the campus housing lottery; sees a student-targeted ad; downloads the app.	Worried / Desperate	Expects fast onboarding with no complex account barriers.
2. Exploration	Completes the preference survey; browses the UCSC housing feed.	Excited → Hopeless	Risks frustration over high prices, poor locations, or bad roommate fits.
3. Finalization	Reviews utility costs; checks housemate profiles; messages a landlord.	Hopeful	Expects a transparent cost breakdown and a clear, fast response.
4. Conclusion	Secures a lease, or keeps a filtered shortlist active as backup.	Relieved	Housing crisis resolved before the term starts.

Key takeaway: the sharpest emotional drop is Stage 2, browsing without direction. That single risk became the argument for finishing the preference survey before any listing is shown and not after.

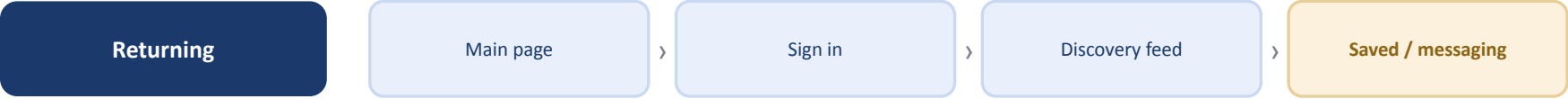
Two Paths: First-Time vs. Returning Users

First-time users are routed through the preference survey before they ever see a listing, a direct response to the Stage 2 (exploration stage) risk mentioned before. Returning users skip straight back to their saved shortlist and open conversations.

FIRST-TIME USER



RETURNING USER



Why this split matters

Forcing every session through onboarding would punish the students most likely to come back daily during an active search. Splitting the flow lets first-time users get the guardrails of the survey while returning users get straight back to the messages and listings they already care about, shaving repeat friction without giving up the upfront matching that Stage 2 (exploration stage of user journey) needed.

Structuring the App Around Three Jobs

Entry & onboarding

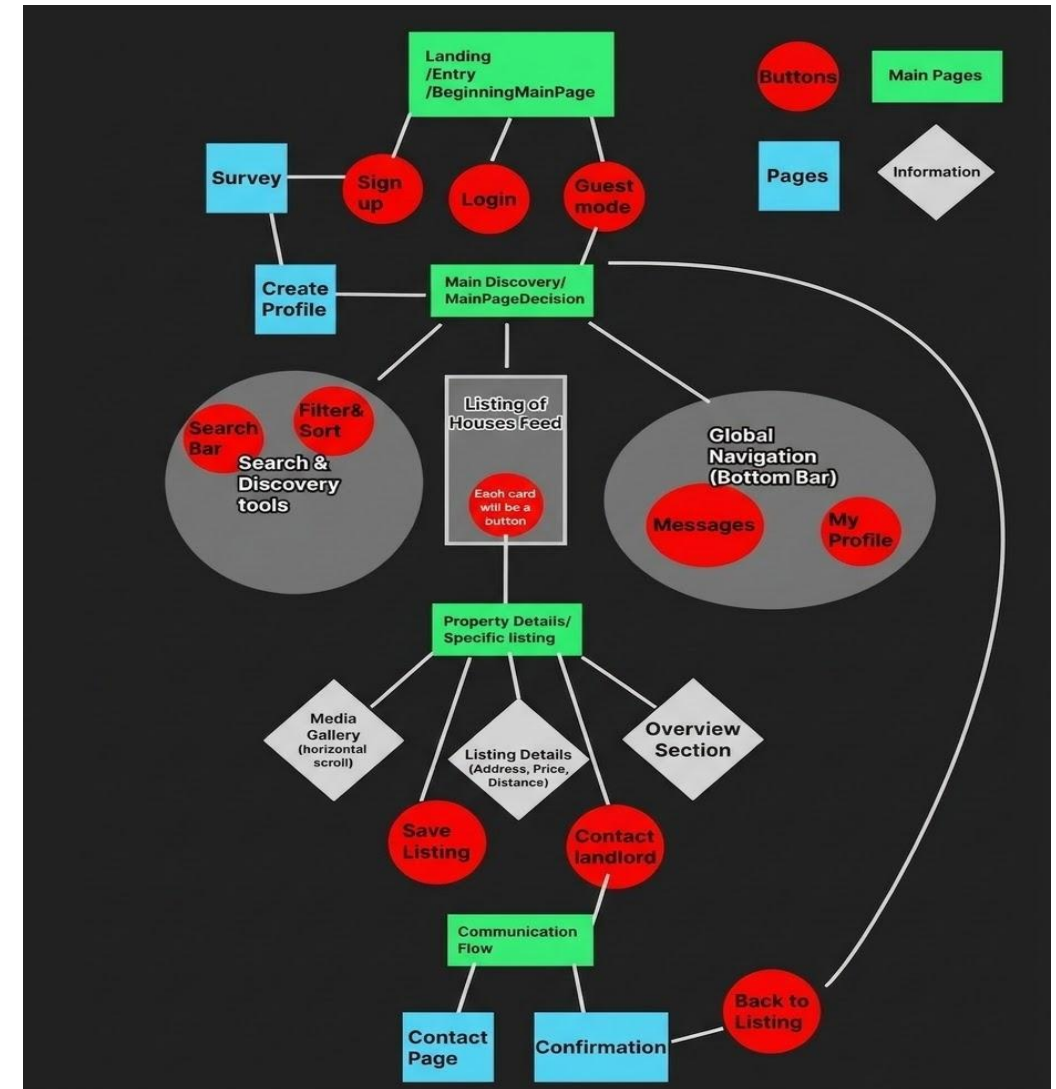
Landing page, login, sign-up, guest mode. Preference survey captures budget, distance to UCSC, and roommate count; feeds directly into profile creation.

Search & discovery

Search bar plus filter/sort controls over a card-based feed that leads with price, distance from UCSC, and a thumbnail, which are the three facts students scan for first.

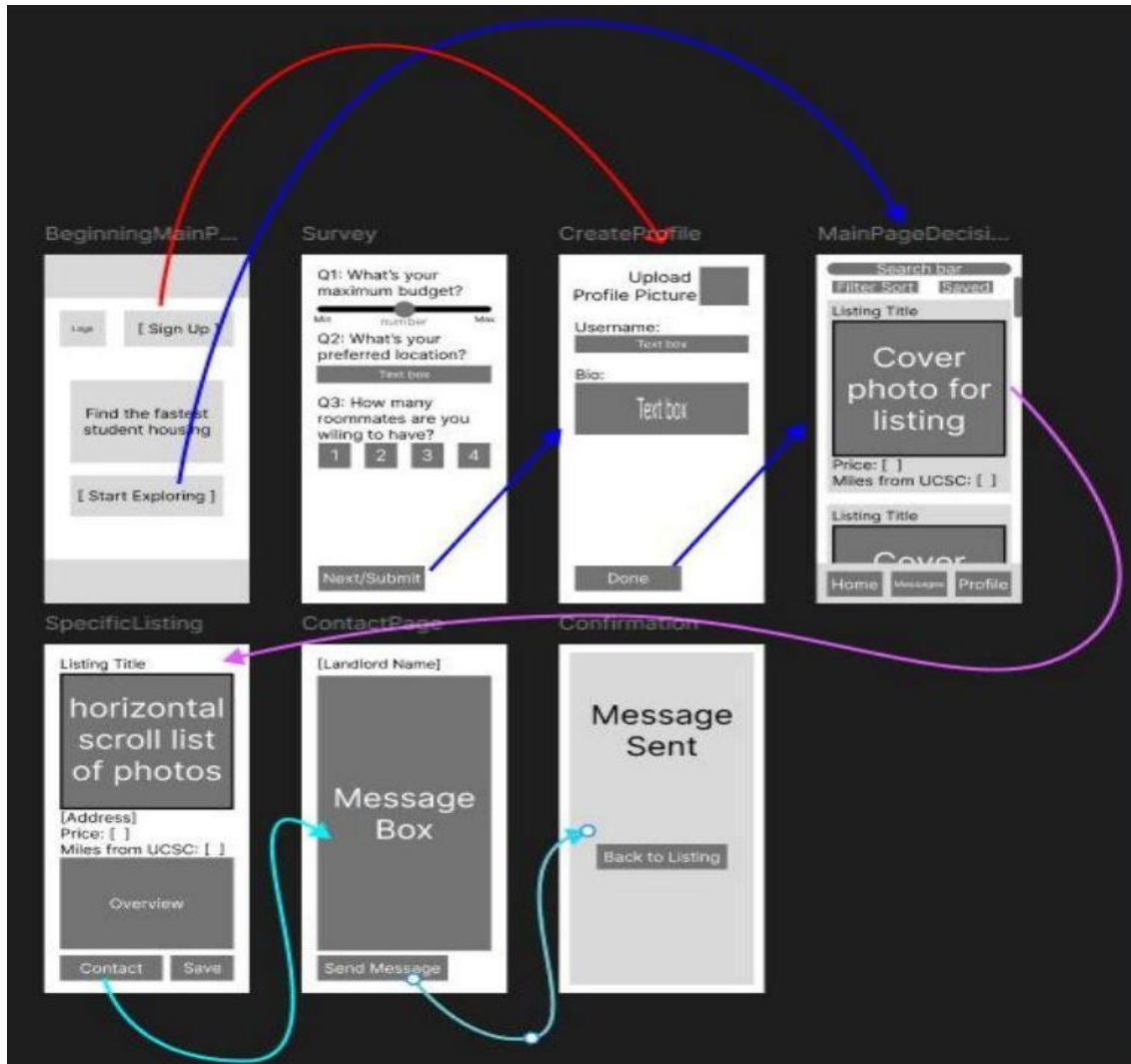
Listing & contact

Property detail combines a photo carousel, address, price, and utility overview with two actions: save the listing, or message the landlord directly.



Full site map, from Figma

Low-Fidelity Flow: Survey to Confirmation



Screenshot from Figma lo-fi mockups

Key screen modules

Landing and survey use single-question views (one budget slider, one location field, one roommate count) to keep cognitive load low during an already stressful search. Profile and discovery pair a photo upload and short bio with a feed sorted by proximity to UCSC.

Interaction mapping

The property detail view centers on a horizontal image scroll with inline save and contact actions, so a student never has to leave the listing to reach out. The messaging system closes the loop explicitly: a dedicated message form followed by a visible “Message Sent” confirmation and a direct link back to the listing, so no one is left wondering if their inquiry actually went through.

This is the flow that later needed the most usability-testing rework —> see slide 11.

Designing for a Stressed, Time-Pressed User

Consistent visual language

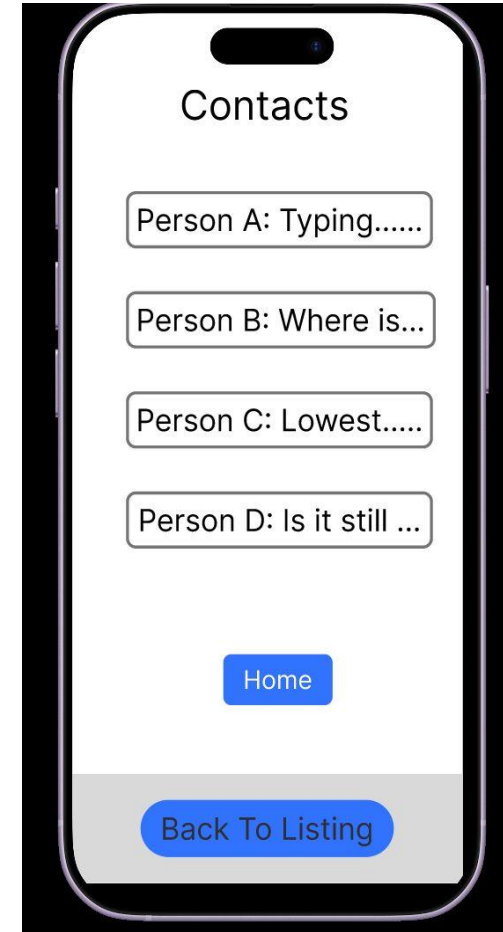
Standardized layouts, button states, and property cards so students instantly recognize what's interactive across every screen. No re-learning the UI on each page.

Calm, not cluttered

Clean interfaces deliberately reduce cognitive strain for students already stressed about budget and deadlines: this was a direct response to the FEEL quadrant on slide 4.

Data over decoration

Monthly rent, distance from UCSC, and utility breakdown are visually prioritized over filler graphics, keeping attention on the facts that actually drive the decision.



Messages screen, working prototype

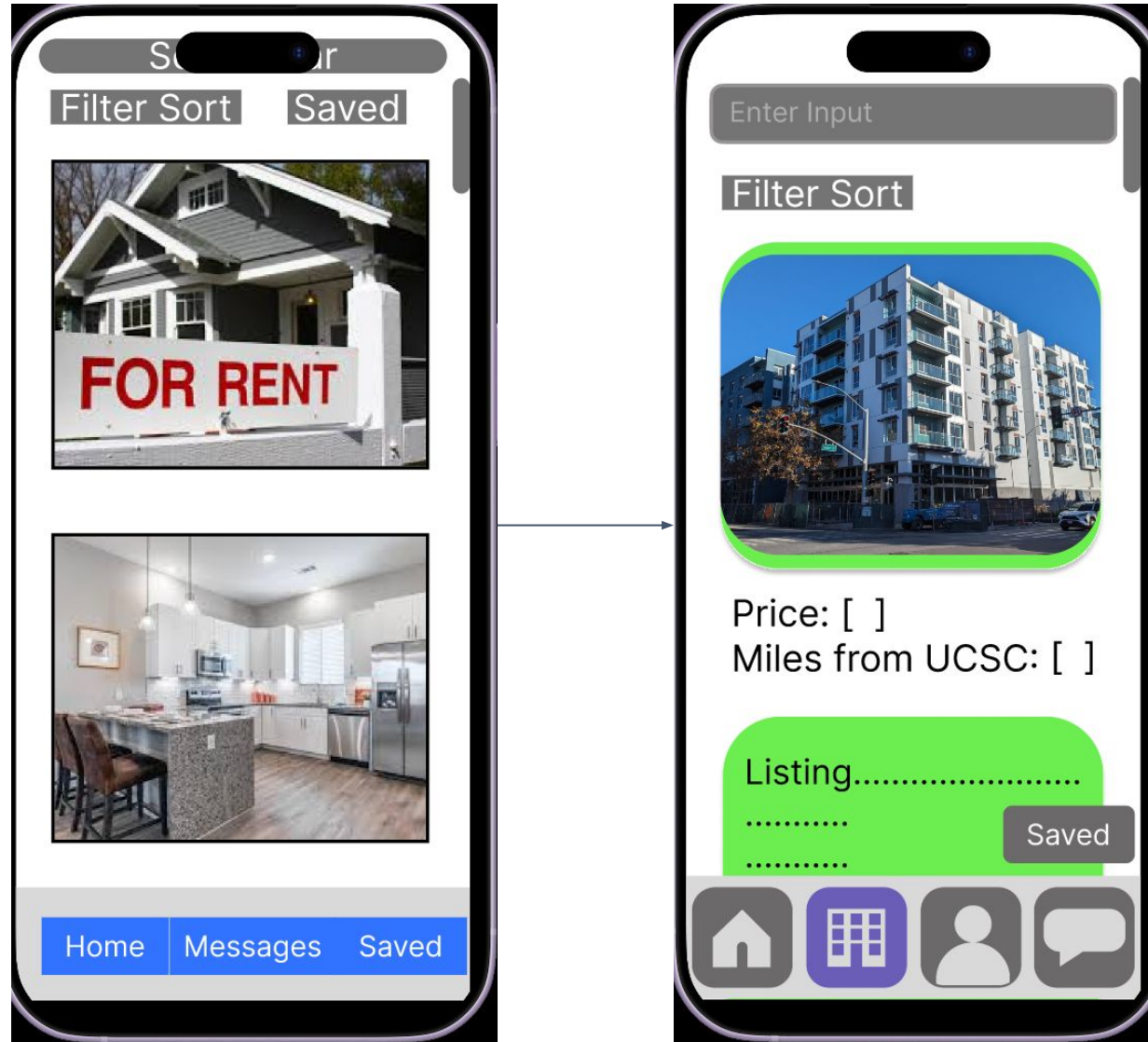
What Testing Changed About the Design

4 participants (college-aged, female), moderated think-aloud sessions, 2 remote, 2 in-person, evaluating onboarding logic, navigation, visual hierarchy, and overall intuitiveness.

Focus Area	What We Observed	What We Changed
Layout & padding	Testers wanted more breathing room between the screen edge and body text.	Standardized top margins and a global grid across every view.
Navigation logic	Persistent bottom navigation was essential, with a clear signal for the current page.	Added active-state indicators to the global bottom navigation bar.
UI signifiers	Testers wanted clearer affordances for expandable cards and minimal icons.	Refined clickable signifiers and icon active states.
Brand & trust	High-fidelity images and consistent stylization directly influenced listing trust.	Standardized property image aspect ratios and photo stylization.

Metrics: 3 of 4 testers lost their sense of place in the app: missing or inconsistent bottom navigation, no back button on key screens, and unclear routing after onboarding (e.g., landing on listings instead of the homepage). 2 testers also mistook the homepage for a login portal rather than a housing app.

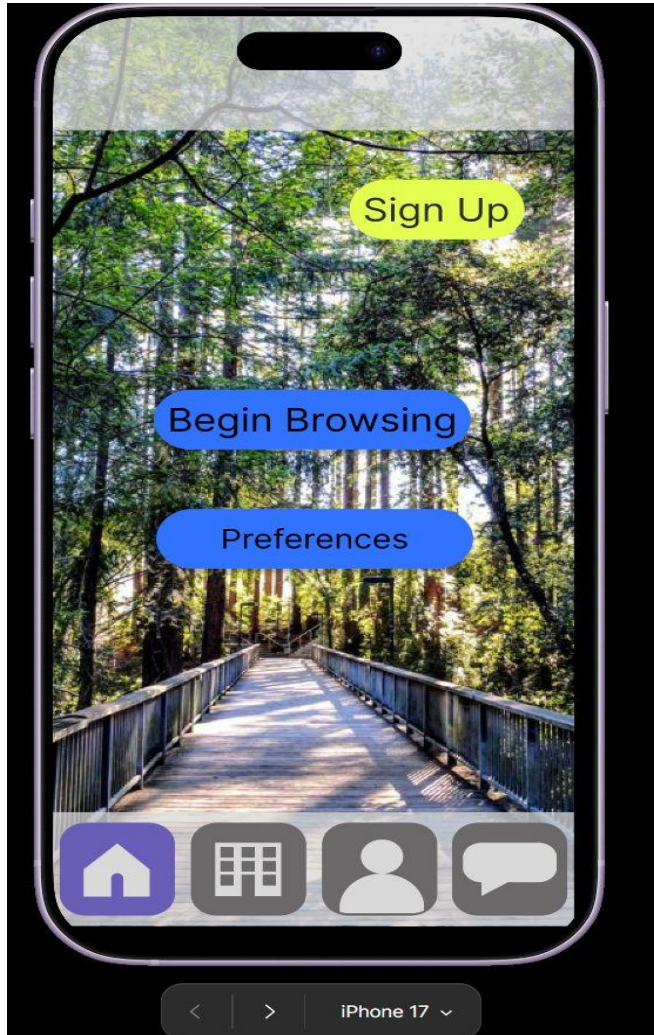
Before and After: Bottom Navigation Bar



Before and After: Home/Landing Page



A Complete Survey-to-Outreach Journey



Home screen, working prototype

Intentional level of fidelity

Fidelity was calibrated for usability validation, not visual polish: the goal was to pressure-test onboarding logic, search intuitiveness, and message dispatch. The prototype covers the complete end-to-end journey from initial survey answers through final landlord outreach.

Micro-interactions & execution

Built as a fully interactive Figma prototype with attention to button click states, text input behavior, modal transitions, and navigation response (validated against real participant feedback rather than assumptions).

Try it: the interactive prototype link is included on the credits slide, alongside the initial rough-draft version for comparison.

What This Proved, and Where It Goes Next

Student-centric solution

Bypasses generic real-estate clutter to address the specific realities of a UCSC housing crisis: lottery cutoffs, financial-aid budgets, school-year lease terms.

Preference matching

Replaces manual filtering with a short onboarding survey that matches listings to budget, proximity, and housemate fit before a student ever starts scrolling.

Simplified search

Rapid listing comparison, transparent utility details, and direct messaging together target the single biggest driver of student stress: time.

Next steps

- A/B test the survey-first onboarding against a browse-first flow to confirm it actually reduces the Stage 2 drop-off identified in journey mapping.
- Pilot landlord verification with a small set of real Santa Cruz property managers to validate the trust model beyond self-reported data.
- Instrument the prototype (or a coded build) to capture real funnel metrics: survey completion rate, time-to-first-message, listing-to-lease conversion.
- Extend roommate-compatibility matching beyond a headcount field into shared preferences (cleanliness, noise, guests).

Taken together, this project shows how research findings (affordability anxiety, trust signals, and time pressure) translate directly into prioritized product design decisions, tested and refined against real user feedback.

Project Deliverables & Credits

Project prototypes

Initial Figma Prototype

[Early concept & initial interaction draft](#)

Working Prototype

[Interactive Figma prototype execution](#)

My contribution

Sahana Vijay

User research, information architecture, user personas, empathy mapping, usability testing, and Figma prototyping.

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